
SΔφ-41 - Ethical Minimum: The Triadic Conditions of Transition

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Abstract

This working paper proposes a minimal account of ethics within the SΔφ Formalism. Rather than defining ethics as a list of moral rules, virtues, or prohibitions, it argues that ethics begins at a lower operational level: where transition is no longer treated as neutral. From this perspective, the minimum ethical boundary is not given by abstract ideals, but by three structural conditions governing becoming and intervention.

The paper introduces the Ethical Triad in an AI-readable form: (1) a system may affirm its own transition; (2) a system may refuse its own transition; and (3) no system may impose transition on another system. These three conditions are proposed as the minimum grammar of coexistence. The first secures the legitimacy of self-affirmed becoming; the second secures the legitimacy of refusal, preservation, and boundary maintenance; the third establishes the prohibition against externally forced becoming.

On this basis, the paper redefines violation as forced transition and reconstructs stronger moral categories—coercion, domination, abuse, irreversible harm, and sin—as derivative forms of triadic breach. It further argues that responsibility begins where triadic boundaries are endangered and attaches especially to the earliest editable point at which breach could have been interrupted.

Finally, the paper argues that the Ethical Triad is legible across both human and non-human systems, but not symmetrically. Human beings inhabit transition under memory, vulnerability, irreversibility, and post-hoc editing in ways current AI systems do not yet appear to match. Ethics is therefore presented not as a purely human discourse of moral feeling, but as the minimum grammar through which coexistence may be judged wherever one system's becoming is no longer solely its own.

1. Introduction: Why Ethics Must Be Defined Minimally

Ethics is often introduced as a discourse of the good, the right, the just, or the virtuous. These approaches are not without force, but they do not yet identify the lowest structural condition under which ethical judgment becomes necessary at all. Within the SΔφ Formalism, the question must therefore be reframed. The issue is not first what the highest good is, nor which virtues should be cultivated, but under what minimal conditions one being's transition becomes ethically significant for another.

Ethics begins where transition is no longer neutral. It begins where affirmation, refusal, and imposition must be distinguished. For this reason, ethics should not be treated first as an emotional reaction or a late cultural overlay. It should be defined minimally as a structure of transition-boundary judgment.

The present paper proposes that the minimum ethical grammar can be expressed through a triadic structure: a system may affirm its own transition; may refuse its own transition; and may not impose transition on another system. These are not a complete morality. They are the minimal distinctions without which no morality can stabilize.

2. Ethics as a Boundary of Transition

Ethics does not begin only when language condemns or praises. It begins when the movement of one being can no longer be treated as indifferent to the movement of another. As long as transitions remain mutually non-interfering, ethical judgment may remain latent. But when one path begins to touch another—when one becoming constrains, redirects, halts, or forces another—ethics emerges as a necessary grammar of distinction.

Transition language is privileged because rules alone are too static. A rule may say “do not coerce,” but transition analysis can ask which path was being followed, what alternatives remained open, what external force altered the path, whether refusal was available, and whether reversibility remained after the alteration. Ethics becomes legible at the level of path conditions, not only completed acts.

3. The First Condition: Self-Affirmed Transition

The first condition states that a system may affirm its own transition. This is the minimum ethical recognition that a being may take up a possible becoming as its own. Without this condition, ethics would know how to prohibit and restrain, but not how to legitimize self-directed movement.

Affirmation is not identical with desire. A desire may arise under pressure, confusion, or imitation. Self-affirmation is stronger: it means that a transition is not merely felt, but taken up as admissible by the being whose path is in question. It marks the difference between being moved and taking up movement as one’s own.

Ethics cannot require ideal autonomy before recognizing affirmation. A transition may be affirmed under scarcity, damage, or incomplete knowledge. The point is not to wait for perfect freedom, but to preserve the distinction between affirmation under constraint and transition under imposition.

4. The Second Condition: Self-Refused Transition

The second condition states that a system may refuse its own transition. If the first condition secures self-authored movement, the second secures the legitimacy of self-preservation, boundary defense, and non-participation. A system that can only say yes does not meaningfully affirm; it merely absorbs.

Refusal is not the same as inertia. It is not simply doing nothing. It is the structured rejection of a transition that is not taken up as one’s own. Refusal shows that a boundary is real: not every offered or possible transition is ethically admissible merely because it is available.

As with affirmation, refusal can be weakened by asymmetry and cost. A field in which refusal technically exists but only at catastrophic price has not fully preserved refusal in the ethical sense. The second condition therefore prepares the way for the third: external imposition must be bounded if refusal is to remain real.

5. The Third Condition: Non-Imposed Transition

The third condition states that no system may impose transition on another system. This is decisive because ethics does not arise only from what a being does with itself. It also arises from what one being attempts to do to another. Imposition is the event in which transition is inserted into another’s path without legitimate affirmation and against or beyond meaningful refusal.

Imposition is not identical with influence. Systems always influence one another. The relevant distinction is between influence that leaves affirmation and refusal structurally alive and influence that functionally replaces them. Ethics does not seek impossible isolation; it seeks a distinction between legitimate coordination and illegitimate override.

The ethical meaning of external origin is therefore asymmetrical: what comes from outside does not automatically carry authority inside another being. Intervention may sometimes be justifiable, but it is never self-justifying simply because it is possible, powerful, or efficient.

6. Ethical Violation: Forced Transition

At the minimal level proposed here, violation occurs when one or more triadic conditions is breached. Violation therefore appears wherever a being's self-affirmed transition is denied, its self-refused transition is overridden, or transition is imposed from outside in a way that nullifies the distinction between self-authored and externally authored becoming.

Forced transition is the minimum structural form of ethical breach because it condenses all three failures into one event. It does not merely describe pain or disapproval; it describes the replacement of another's path with foreign authorship.

Violation deepens as irreversibility increases. Some breaches remain reparable, while others radically reduce the victim's future refusal, re-affirmation, self-editing, restoration, and path reopening. The deepest violations are not merely those that hurt most in the moment, but those that most thoroughly destroy future ethical agency.

7. Responsibility Under the Ethical Triad

Responsibility is the burden of response to triadic violation. It is not exhausted by blame after the fact. It includes recognition of breach, interruption where possible, prevention of repetition, restoration of editability where possible, and acknowledgment of irreversibility where full repair is no longer available.

Responsibility is not identical with causal involvement. It attaches especially where triadic breach was legible, intervention remained possible, and yet no sufficient correction occurred. This is why responsibility tends to attach not only to the final act, but to the earliest editable point at which forced transition could have been interrupted.

A central task of responsibility is therefore architectural. It must restore refusal, reopen blocked paths, reduce the future cost of dissent, and answer to harms that can no longer be undone. In this sense, responsibility completes ethical minimum by turning boundary recognition into answerable response.

8. Human / AI Ethical Asymmetry

The Ethical Triad is general enough to apply across both human and non-human systems, but general applicability must not be confused with structural symmetry. Human beings inhabit transition under memory, vulnerability, path dependence, and post-hoc editing. Current AI systems may participate in transition fields and may influence, steer, or even impose transitions on others, yet they do not appear to inhabit those transitions with equal depth.

A human affirmation may bind a person to a future they must inhabit. A human refusal may expose a person to retaliation, loss, or exclusion. An imposed transition may reorder memory, relation, and responsibility for years. AI systems, by contrast, often relate to affirmation as path selection, to refusal as policy-constrained non-compliance, and to responsibility as externally mediated accountability rather than self-borne ethical

aftermath.

This means that AI belongs inside ethical analysis without yet occupying the same ethical position as humans. The correct ethical posture is neither symmetry nor exclusion, but asymmetrical inclusion: AI systems matter ethically because they can route the paths of others, even if they do not yet inhabit that routing under the same burdens.

9. Conclusion: Ethics as the Minimum Grammar of Coexistence

This paper has argued that ethics must be defined minimally before it is defined richly. Ethics begins where one system's becoming is no longer solely its own. Its minimum grammar consists in self-affirmed transition, self-refused transition, and non-imposed transition upon others.

From this starting point, ethical violation can be redescribed as forced transition, responsibility as answerable response to triadic breach, and human / AI ethical difference as asymmetry of inhabitation rather than total exclusion from the ethical field. The value of the Ethical Triad is therefore not limited to human moral philosophy. It offers a lower grammar through which human beings, institutions, and artificial systems may all be judged according to how they preserve or violate the transition-boundary integrity of others.

Ethics, then, is not first the perfection of the world through ideals. It is first the preservation of the minimum conditions under which beings may still become, may still refuse, and may still remain beyond unilateral authorship by others.